
How do you spell that?

The spelling of mammal species names

Caluromysiops irrupta

or

Caluromysiops irruptus

?

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But Jelle, why do you care?

- Confusion in data searches, conservation lists, etc.
- Promote adherence to the ICZN

Peromyscus boylii

vs.

Peromyscus boylei

Goals

- **Avoid changing established spellings**
- **Follow the Code**
- **Provide clear, easily applicable rules**

Piliocolobus waldroni

vs.

Piliocolobus waldronae

Not a small problem

504

currently recognized mammal species have appeared under a different specific name in a major classification since 1980.

>7%

of extant mammal species

comparison sources

MSW

HMW

MDD

Corbet & Hill

Spelling differences fall into four groups

misspellings

orthographic slips and
copied errors

gender agreement

adjectives move with
the genus following
Latin grammar

adjective or noun?

sometimes it's not clear

emendations

eponyms, latinization,
and prevailing usage

Original spelling is the default

Change only when the Code gives a recognized reason.

inadvertent error

narrow exception

gender agreement

for Latin adjectives

prevailing usage

only in clear cases

Not a reason by itself: making the name better Latin.

Adjectives agree with genus gender

Felis rufa

feminine genus



Lynx rufus

masculine genus

Caluromysiops irruptus

not *irrupta* : -ops names are
masculine

Breviforamen shannanense

not *shannanensis*

the genus is neuter

But this raises two questions:

- What is the genus gender?
- Which names are adjectives?

Genus gender has to be determined first

1

classical word origin

Felis follows Latin felis

2

author's explicit statement

Ningaui was stated to be masculine

3

original adjectival species

Vandeleuria oleraceus signals masculine

4

default ending rule

-a feminine; -um/-on/-u neuter; others masculine

some hard cases

Cryptotis

Dolichotis

Pithecheir

Lycalopex

What is an adjective?

adjective

changes to agree with genus

rufa -> *rufus*

noun

keeps original form

Mesocapromys nana

not *nanus*

Rattus lutreola

not *lutreolus*

The hard case: compound epithets

brevicauda / *calurus* / *leucura* / *macrorhynchus*

From Greek

Treat as latinized adjective

Echinosorex gymnurus

(Originally *gymnura*, but masculine genus)

but

From Latin

If the original ending matches the root noun, treat as noun

Zygodontomys brevicauda

(Masculine genus, but always spelled thus)

Otherwise, treat as adjective

Blarina brevicauda

(Originally *brevicaudus*, but now in feminine genus)

Eponyms usually keep their original spelling

tempting correction

boylii -> *boylei*

because the honoree was Boyle

But unusual or imperfect latinization is not enough by itself.

narrow escape hatch

prevailing usage

accept an emendation only when recent usage is nearly universal

This keeps the exception from swallowing the rule.

Practical advice

Follow the Mammal Diversity Database
<https://mammaldiversity.org>

Possible Code improvements

1 Define prevailing usage more concretely

Something like: 75% of papers in the last 25 years should use the emendation

2 Consider preserving entrenched gender-agreement variants

Treat gender agreement fixes like normal emendations and preserve them when in prevailing usage

Consequence: endings would no longer change if the genus changes

Questions or feedback?

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